

A Demonstration of the Being and
Attributes of God.

More particularly in answer to Mr. Hobbes, Spinoza,
and their followers.

Being the substance of eight sermons preached in the
year 1704 at the lecture founded by the honourable
Robert Boyle, Esquire.

All those who either are or pretend to be atheists, who either disbelieve the being of God or would be thought to do so or, which is all one, who deny the principal attributes of the divine nature and suppose God to be an unintelligent being which acts merely by necessity, that is, which in any tolerable propriety of speech acts not at all, but is only acted upon – all men that are atheists, I say, in this sense, must be so upon one or other of these three accounts.

Either, firstly, because, being extremely ignorant and stupid, they have never duly considered any thing at all, nor made any just use of their natural reason to discover even the plainest and most obvious truths, but have spent their time in a manner of life very little superior to that of beasts.

Or, secondly, because, being totally debauched and corrupted in their practice, they have by a vicious and degenerate life corrupted the principles of their nature and defaced the reason of their own minds. And instead of fairly and impartially enquiring into the rules and obligations of nature and the reasons and fitness of things, [they] have accustomed themselves only to mock and scoff at religion and, being under the power of evil habits and the slavery of unreasonable and indulged lusts, are resolved not to harken to any reasoning which would oblige them to forsake their beloved vices.

Or, thirdly, because in the way of speculative reasoning and upon the principles of philosophy, they pretend that the arguments used against the being and attributes of God seem to them, after the strictest and fullest enquiry, to be more strong and conclusive than those by which we endeavor to prove these great truths.

These seem the only causes which can be imagined of any man

disbelieving the being and attributes of God; and no man can be supposed to be an atheist but upon one or other of these three accounts. Now to the two former of these three sorts of men, namely, to such as are wholly ignorant and stupid, or to such as through habitual debauchery have brought themselves to a custom of mocking and scoffing at all religion and will not hearken to any fair reasoning, it is not my present business to apply myself. The one of these wants to be instructed in the first principles of reason as well as religion; the other disbelieves only for a present false interest and because he is desirous that the thing should not be true. The one has not yet arrived at the use of his natural faculties; the other has renounced them and declares he will not be argued with as a rational creature. It is therefore the third sort of atheists only (namely, those who in the way of speculative reasoning and upon the principles of philosophy pretend that the arguments brought against the being and attributes of God do, upon the strictest examination, appear to them to be the more strong and conclusive than those by which these great truths are attempted to be proved) – these, I say, are the only atheistical persons to whom my present discourse can be supposed to be directed, or indeed who are capable of being reasoned with at all.

Now before I enter upon the main argument, I shall premise several concessions which these men, upon their own principles, are unavoidably obliged to make.

And, firstly, they must of necessity own that supposing it cannot be proved to be true, yet it is a thing very desirable and which any wise man would wish to be true for the great benefit and happiness of men that there was a God, an intelligent, and wise, and just, and good being to govern the world. Whatever hypothesis these men can possibly frame, whatever argument they can invent by which they would exclude God and providence out of the world, that very argument or hypothesis will of necessity lead them to this concession. If they argue that our notion of God arises not from nature and reason but from the art and contrivance of politicians, that argument itself forces them to confess that it is manifestly for the interest of human society that it should be believed there is a God. If they suppose that the world was made by chance and is every moment subject to be destroyed by chance again, no man can be so absurd as to contend that it is as comfortable and desirable to live in such an uncertain state of things, and so continually liable to ruin without any hope of renovation, as in a world that were under the preservation and conduct of a powerful, wise,

and good God.¹ If they argue against the being of God from the faults and defects which they imagine they can find in the frame and constitution of the visible and material world, this supposition obliges them to acknowledge that it would have been better the world had been made by an intelligent and wise being who might have prevented all faults and imperfections. If they argue against providence from the faultiness and inequality which they think they discover in the management of the moral world, this is a plain concession that it is a thing more fit and desirable in itself that the world should be governed by a just and good being than by mere chance or unintelligent necessity. Lastly, if they suppose the world to be eternally and necessarily self-existent, and consequently that every thing in it is established by a blind and eternal fatality, no rational man can at the same time deny but that liberty and choice, or the free power of acting, is a more eligible state than to be determined thus in all our actions, as a stone is to move downward by an absolute and inevitable fate.

In a word, which way soever they turn themselves and whatever hypothesis they make concerning the original and frame of things, nothing is so certain and undeniable as that man, considered without the protection and conduct of a superior being, is in a far worse case than upon supposition of the being and government of God and of men's being under his peculiar conduct, protection, and favor. Man, of himself, is infinitely insufficient for his own happiness. "He is liable to many evils and miseries, which he can neither prevent nor redress; he is full of wants which he cannot supply; and compassed about with infirmities which he cannot remove; and obnoxious to dangers which he can never sufficiently provide against . . . He is secure of nothing that he enjoys in the world, and uncertain of everything that he hopes for; he is apt to grieve for what he cannot have, and eagerly to desire what he is never able to obtain." ² Under which evil

¹ "... maria ac terras coelumque . . .
... una dies dabit exitio, multosque per annos
sustentata ruet moles et machina mundi.
... dictis dabit ipsa fidem res
forsitan et graviter terrarum motibus ortis
omnia conquassari in parvo tempore cernes."

["... the seas, the lands and the sky . . . just one day will bring to destruction, and the mass and machinery of the universe, upheld for many years, will crash to ruin . . . Things themselves will perhaps give credit to my words, and in a short time you will see all things violently convulsed and shocked by earthquakes."] T. Lucretius Caro, *De Rerum Natura*, book 5, vv. 92-106.

² Archbishop John Tillotson's sermon on Job xxviii, 28, in John Tillotson, *The Works of the Most Reverend Dr. John Tillotson*, seventh edition (London, 1714), p. 22.

circumstances it is evident there can be no sufficient support but in the belief of a wise and good God and in the hopes which true religion affords. Whether, therefore, the being and attributes of God can be demonstrated or not, it must at least be confessed by all rational and wise men to be a thing very desirable and which they would heartily wish to be true, that there was a God, an intelligent and wise, a just and good being, to govern the world.

Now the use I desire to make of this concession is only this: that, since the men I am arguing with are unavoidably obliged to confess that it is a thing very desirable at least that there should be a God, they must of necessity upon their own principles be very willing, nay desire upon all things, to be convinced that their present opinion is an error, and sincerely hope that the contrary may be demonstrated to them to be true. And, consequently, they are bound with all seriousness, attention, and impartiality to consider the weight of the arguments by which the being and attributes of God may be proved to them.

Secondly, all such persons as I am speaking of, who profess themselves to be atheists not upon any present interest or lust but purely upon the principles of reason and philosophy, are bound by these principles to acknowledge that all mocking and scoffing at religion, all jesting and turning arguments of reason into drollery and ridicule, is the most unmanly and unreasonable thing in the world. And, consequently, they are obliged to exclude out of their number, as irrational and self-condemned persons and unworthy to be argued with, all such scoffers at religion who deride at all adventures without hearing reason, and who will not use the means of being convinced and satisfied. Hearing the reasons of the case with patience and lack of prejudice is an equity which men owe to every truth that can in any manner concern them and which is necessary to the discovery of every kind of error. How much more in things of the utmost importance!

Thirdly, since the persons I am discoursing to cannot but own that the supposition of the being of God is in itself most desirable and for the benefit of the world that it should be true, they must of necessity grant further that, supposing the being and attributes of God to be things not indeed demonstrable to be true but only possible and such as cannot be demonstrated to be false, as most certainly they cannot; and, much more, supposing them once made to appear probable and but more likely to be true than the contrary opinion; nothing is more evident, even upon these

suppositions only, than that men ought in all reason to live piously and virtuously in the world and that vice and immorality are, upon all accounts and under all hypotheses, the most absurd and inexcusable things in nature.

Thus much being premised, which no atheist who pretends to be a rational and fair enquirer into things can possibly avoid granting (and other atheists, I have before said, are not to be disputed with at all, as being enemies to reason no less than to religion, and therefore absolutely self-condemned), I proceed now to the main thing I at first proposed, namely, to endeavor to show to such considering persons as I have already described that the being and attributes of God are not only possible or barely probable in themselves, but also strictly demonstrable to any unprejudiced mind from the most incontestable principles of right reason.

And here, because the persons I am at present dealing with must be supposed not to believe any Revelation, nor acknowledge any authority which they will submit to but only the bare force of reasoning, I shall not, at this time, draw any testimony from Scripture, nor make use of any sort of authority, nor lay any stress on any popular arguments in the matter before us, but confine myself to the rules of strict and demonstrative argumentation.

Now many arguments there are by which the being and attributes of God have been undertaken to be demonstrated. And perhaps most of those arguments, if thoroughly understood, rightly stated, fully pursued, and duly separated from the false and uncertain reasoning which have sometimes been intermixed with them, would at length appear to be substantial and conclusive. But because I would endeavor, as far as possible, to avoid all manner of perplexity and confusion, therefore I shall not at this time use any variety of arguments, but endeavor, by one clear and plain series of propositions necessarily connected and following one from another, to demonstrate the certainty of the being of God and to deduce in order the necessary attributes of his nature, so far as by our finite reason we are enabled to discover and apprehend them. And because it is not to my present purpose to explain and illustrate things to them that believe, but only to convince unbelievers and settle them that doubt by strict and undeniable reason, therefore I shall not allege anything which, however really true and useful, may yet be liable to contradiction or dispute, but shall endeavor to urge such propositions only as cannot be denied without departing from that reason which all atheists pretend to be the foundation of their unbelief. Only it is absolutely necessary before all things that they

consent to lay aside all manner of prejudices, and especially such as have been apt to arrive from the too frequent use of terms of art which have no ideas belonging to them, and from the common receiving of certain maxims of philosophy as true which at bottom seem to be only propositions without any meaning or signification at all.

I

First, then, it is absolutely and undeniably certain that *something has existed from all eternity*. This is so evident and undeniable a proposition, that no atheist in any age has ever presumed to assert the contrary, and therefore there is little need of being particular in the proof of it. For, since something now is, it is evident that something always was, otherwise the things that now are must have been produced out of nothing, absolutely and without a cause, which is a plain contradiction in terms. For, to say a thing is produced and yet that there is no cause at all for that production, is to say that something is effected when it is effected by nothing, that is, at the same time when it is not effected at all. Whatever exists has a cause, a reason, a ground of its existence, a foundation on which its existence relies, a ground or reason why it does exist rather than not exist, either in the necessity of its own nature (and then it must have been of itself eternal), or in the will of some other being (and then that other being must, at least in the order of nature and causality, have existed before it).

That something, therefore, has really existed from eternity, is one of the most certain and evident truths in the world, acknowledged by all men and disputed by no one. Yet, as to the manner how it can be, there is nothing in nature more difficult for the mind of men to conceive than this very first plain and self-evident truth. For how anything can have existed eternally, that is, how an eternal duration can be now actually past, is a thing utterly as impossible for our narrow understandings to comprehend, as anything that is not an express contradiction can be imagined to be. And yet, to deny the truth of the proposition, that an eternal duration is now actually past, would be to assert something still far more unintelligible, even a real and express contradiction.

The use I would make of this observation is this: that since in all questions concerning the nature and perfections of God (or concerning anything to which the idea of eternity or infinity is joined), though we can indeed demonstrate certain propositions to be true, yet it is impossible for

us to comprehend or frame any adequate or complete ideas of the manner how the things so demonstrated can be. Therefore, when once any proposition is clearly demonstrated to be true, it ought not to disturb us that there be perhaps perplexing difficulties on the other side which, merely for want of adequate ideas of the manner of the existence of the things demonstrated, are not easy to be cleared. Indeed, were it possible there should be any proposition which could equally be demonstrated on both sides of the question, or which could on both sides be reduced to imply a contradiction (as some have very inconsiderately asserted), this, it must be confessed, would alter the case. Upon this absurd supposition, all difference of true and false, all thinking and reasoning, and the use of all our faculties, would be entirely at an end. But when to demonstration on the one side there are proposed on the other only difficulties raised from our want of having adequate ideas of the things themselves, this ought not to be esteemed an objection of any real weight.

It is directly and clearly demonstrable, and acknowledged to be so even by all atheists who ever lived, that something has been from eternity. All the objections, therefore, raised against the eternity of anything, grounded merely on our want of having an adequate idea of eternity, ought to be looked upon as of no real solidity. Thus in other like instances. It is demonstrable, for example, that something must be actually infinite. All the metaphysical difficulties, therefore, which arise usually from applying the measures and relations of things finite to what is infinite and from supposing finites to be *aliquot* parts of infinite, when indeed they are not properly so but only as mathematical points to quantity, which have no proportion at all (and from imagining of infinities to be equal, when in things disparate they manifestly are not so, an infinite line being not only not equal to, but infinitely less than, an infinite surface, and an infinite surface than space infinite in all dimensions) – all metaphysical difficulties, I say, arising from false suppositions of this kind, ought to be esteemed vain and of no force. Again, it is in like manner demonstrable that quantity is infinitely divisible. All the objections, therefore, raised by supposing the sum total of all infinities to be equal when in disparate parts they manifestly are not so, and by comparing the imaginary equality or inequality of the number of the parts of unequal quantities whose parts have really no number at all (they all having parts without number), ought to be looked upon as weak and altogether inconclusive; to ask whether the parts of unequal quantities be equal in number or not, when they have no number at all,

being the same thing as to ask whether two lines drawn from differently distant points, and each of them continued infinitely, be equal in length or not, that is, whether they end together, when neither of them have any end at all.

II

*There has existed from eternity some one unchangeable and independent being.*³ For, since something must needs have been from eternity, as has been already proved and is granted on all hands, either there has always existed some one unchangeable and independent being from which all other beings that are or ever were in the universe have received their original, or else there has been an infinite succession of changeable and dependent beings produced one from another in an endless progression without any original cause at all. Now this latter supposition is so very absurd that, though all atheism must in its accounts of most things (as shall be shown hereafter) terminate in it, yet I think very few atheists ever were so weak as openly and directly to defend it. For it is plainly impossible and contradictory to itself. I shall not argue against it from the supposed impossibility of infinite succession, barely and absolutely considered in itself, for a reason which shall be mentioned hereafter. But, if we consider such an infinite progression as one entire endless series of dependent beings, it is plain this whole series of beings can have no cause from without of its existence because in it are supposed to be included all things that are, or ever were, in the universe. And it is plain it can have no reason within itself for its existence because no one being in this infinite succession is supposed to be self-existent or necessary (which is the only ground or reason of existence of anything that can be imagined within the thing itself, as will presently more fully appear), but every one dependent on the foregoing. And, where no part is necessary, it is manifest the whole cannot be necessary – absolute necessity of existence not being an extrinsic, relative, and accidental denomination but an inward and essential property of the nature of the thing which so exists.

An infinite succession, therefore, of merely dependent beings without any original independent cause is a series of beings that has neither neces-

³ The meaning of this proposition, and all [that] the argument here requires, is that there must needs have always been some independent being, some one at least. To show that there can be no more than one is not the design of this proposition but of the seventh.

sity, nor cause, nor any reason or ground at all of its existence either within itself or from without. That is, it is an express contradiction and impossibility. It is a supposing something to be caused (because it is granted in every one of its stages of succession not to be necessarily and of itself), and yet that, in the whole, it is caused absolutely by nothing, which every man knows is a contradiction to imagine done in time; and because duration in this case makes no difference, it is equally a contradiction to suppose it done from eternity. And consequently there must, on the contrary, of necessity have existed from eternity some one immutable and independent being.

To suppose an infinite succession of changeable and dependent beings produced one from another in an endless progression without any original cause at all is only a driving back from one step to another and, as it were, removing out of sight the question concerning the ground or reason of the existence of things.⁴ It is, in reality and in point of argument, the very same supposition as it would be to suppose one continued being of beginningless and endless duration neither self-existent and necessary in itself, nor having its existence founded in any self-existent cause, which is directly absurd and contradictory.

Otherwise, thus: either there has always existed some unchangeable and independent being from which all other beings have received their original, or else there has been an infinite succession of changeable and dependent beings, produced one from another in an endless progression without any original cause at all. According to this latter supposition, there is nothing

⁴ This matter has been well illustrated by a late able writer: "Suppose a chain hung down out of the heavens from an unknown height, and though every link of it gravitated toward the Earth and what it hung upon was not visible, yet it did not descend but kept its situation; and [suppose] upon this a question should arise, what supported or kept up this chain? Would it be a sufficient answer to say that the first or lowest link hung upon the second, or that next above it, [and] the first, or rather the first and the second together, upon the third, and so on *in infinitum*? For what holds up the *whole*? A chain of ten links would fall down unless something able to bear it hindered. One of twenty, if not staid by something of a yet greater strength, [would fall] in proportion to the increase of weight, and therefore one of infinite links, certainly, if not sustained by something infinitely strong and capable to bear up an infinite weight. And thus it is in a chain of causes and effects tending or, as it were, gravitating towards some end. The last or lowest depends or, as one may say, is suspended upon the cause above it. This again, if it be not the first cause, is suspended as an effect upon something above it, etc. And if they should be infinite, unless agreeably to what has been said there is some cause upon which all hang or depend, they would be but an infinite effect without an efficient. And so to assert there is any such thing would be as great an absurdity as to say that a finite or little weight wants something to sustain it, but an infinite one, or the greatest, does not." W. Wollaston, *The Religion of Nature Delineated* (London, Samuel Palmer, 1724; reprint New York, Garland Publishing Co., 1978), p. 67.

in the universe self-existent or necessarily existing. And if so, then it was originally equally possible that from eternity there should never have existed anything at all, as that there should from eternity have existed a succession of changeable and dependent beings. Which being supposed, then, what is it that has from eternity determined such a succession of beings to exist, rather than that from eternity there should never have existed anything at all? Necessity it was not because it was equally possible, in this supposition, that they should not have existed at all. Chance is nothing but a mere word, without any signification. And other being it is supposed there was none, to determine the existence of these. Their existence, therefore, was determined by nothing; neither by any necessity in the nature of the things themselves, because it is supposed that none of them are self-existent, nor by any other being, because no other is supposed to exist. That is to say, of two equally possible things, viz., whether anything or nothing should from eternity have existed, the one is determined rather than the other absolutely by nothing, which is an express contradiction. And consequently, as before, there must on the contrary of necessity have existed from eternity some one immutable and independent being. Which, what it is, remains in the next place to be inquired.

III

That unchangeable and independent being which has existed from eternity, without any external cause of its existence, must be self-existent, that is, necessarily existing. For whatever exists must either have come into being out of nothing, absolutely without cause, or it must have been produced by some external cause, or it must be self-existent. Now to arise out of nothing absolutely without any cause has been already shown to be a plain contradiction. To have been produced by some external cause cannot possibly be true of every thing, but something must have existed eternally and independently, as has likewise been shown already. Which remains, therefore, [is] that that being which has existed independently from eternity must of necessity be self-existent. Now to be self-existent is not to be produced by itself, for that is an express contradiction, but it is (which is the only idea we can frame of self-existence, and without which the word seems to have no signification at all) – it is, I say, to exist by an absolute necessity originally in the nature of the thing itself. And this necessity must be antecedent, not indeed in time, to the existence of the being itself

(because that is eternal), but it must be antecedent in the natural order of our ideas to our supposition of its being. That is, this necessity must not barely be consequent upon our supposition of the existence of such a being (for then it would not be a necessity absolutely such in itself, nor be the ground or foundation of the existence of anything, being on the contrary only a consequent of it), but it must antecedently force itself upon us whether we will or no, even when we are endeavoring to suppose that no such being exists. For example, when we are endeavoring to suppose that there is no being in the universe that exists necessarily, we always find in our minds (besides the foregoing demonstration of something being self-existent from the impossibility of every thing's being dependent) – we always find in our minds, I say, some ideas, as of infinity and eternity, which to remove (that is, to suppose that there is no being, no substance in the universe to which these attributes or modes of existence are necessarily inherent) is a contradiction in the very terms. For modes and attributes exist only by the existence of the substance to which they belong. Now he that can suppose eternity and immensity, and consequently the substance by whose existence these modes or attributes exist, removed out of the universe, may, if he please, as easily remove the relation of equality between twice two and four.

That to suppose immensity removed out of the universe, or not necessarily eternal, is an express contradiction is intuitively evident to every one who attends to his own ideas and considers the essential nature of things. To suppose any part of space removed is to suppose it removed from and out of itself; and to suppose the whole to be taken away is supposing it to be taken away from itself, that is, to be taken away while it still remains, which is a contradiction in terms.⁵ There is no obscurity in the argument but what arises to those who think immense space to be absolutely nothing, which notion is itself likewise an express contradiction. For nothing is that which has no properties or modes whatsoever, that is to say, it is that of which nothing can truly be affirmed and of which every thing can truly be denied, which is not the case of immensity or space.

From this third proposition it follows, first, that the only true idea of a self-existent or necessarily existing being is the idea of a being the supposition of whose not-existing is an express contradiction. For, since it is

⁵ "Moveantur partes spatii de locis suis, et movebuntur (ut ita dicam) de seipsis." ["Suppose the parts of space to be moved out of their places, and they will be moved (if I may say so) out of themselves."] *NP*, Book 1, Scholium to Definition 8, p. 48.

absolutely impossible but there must be somewhat self-existing, that is, [something] which exists by the necessity of its own nature, it is plain that that necessity cannot be a necessity consequent upon any foregoing supposition (because nothing can be antecedent to that which is self-existent, no not its own will, so as to be the cause or ground of its own existence), but it must be a necessity absolutely such in its own nature. Now a necessity not relatively or consequentially, but absolutely such in its own nature, is nothing else but its being a plain impossibility or implying a contradiction to suppose the contrary. For instance, the relation of equality between twice two and four is an absolute necessity only because it is an immediate contradiction in terms to suppose them unequal. This is the only idea we can frame of an absolute necessity, and to use the word in any other sense seems to be using it without any signification at all.

If any one now asks, what sort of idea the idea of that being is, the supposition of whose not-existing is thus an express contradiction, I answer: it is that first and simplest idea we can possibly frame; an idea necessarily and essentially included or presupposed as a *sine qua non* in every other idea whatsoever; an idea which (unless we forbear thinking at all) we cannot possibly extirpate or remove out of our minds of a most simple being, absolutely eternal and infinite, original and independent. For, that he who supposes there is no original independent being in the universe supposes a contradiction, has been shown already. And that he who supposes there may possibly be no eternal and infinite being in the universe, supposes likewise a contradiction, is evident from hence (beside that these two attributes do necessarily follow from self-originate independent existence, as shall be shown hereafter), that when he has done his utmost in endeavoring to imagine that no such being exists, he cannot avoid imagining an eternal and infinite nothing.⁶ That is, he will imagine eternity and immensity removed out of the universe, and yet that at the same time they still continue there, as has been above distinctly explained.

This argument the Cartesians, who supposed the idea of immensity to be the idea of matter, have been greatly perplexed with. For however in words they have contradicted themselves, yet in reality they have more easily been driven to that most intolerable absurdity of asserting matter to be a necessary being, than being able to remove out of their minds the idea

⁶ See the answer to a Seventh Letter at the end of this book [Supplementary text III].

of immensity as existing necessarily and inseparably from eternity.⁷ Which absurdity and inextricable perplexity of theirs, in respect of the idea of immensity, shows that they found *that* indeed to be necessary and impossible to be removed; but in respect of matter it was only a perverse applying [of] an idea to an object whereto it no ways belongs. For, that it is indeed absolutely impossible and contradictory to suppose matter necessarily existing, shall be demonstrated presently.

Secondly, from hence it follows that there is no man whatsoever who makes any use his reason but may easily become more certain of the being of a supreme independent cause than he can be of any thing else besides his own existence. For how much thought soever it may require to demonstrate the other attributes of such a being, as it may do to demonstrate the greatest mathematical certainties (of which more hereafter), yet, as to its existence, that there is somewhat eternal, infinite, and self-existing, which must be the cause and origin of all other things, this is one of the first and most natural conclusions that any man who thinks at all can frame in his mind; and no man can any more doubt of this than he can doubt whether twice two be equal to four. It is possible indeed a man may in some sense be ignorant of this first and plain truth by being utterly stupid and not thinking at all (for though it is absolutely impossible for him to imagine

⁷ "... puto implicare contradictionem ut mundus sit finitus," i.e., "... I think it implies a contradiction for the world to be finite." R. Descartes, Letter to More of 15 April 1649, in *Oeuvres de Descartes*, eds. C. Adam and P. Tannery (Paris, 1897-1913; reprint Paris, J. Vrin, 1964-76), vol. 5, p. 345.

And his follower Mr. Regis, "Mais peut etre," says he, "que je raisonne mal" etc. "But perhaps I argue ill when I conclude that the property my idea has to represent extension {that is, in the sense of the Cartesians, matter} comes from extension itself as its cause. For what hinders me from believing that if this property comes not from myself yet at least it may come from some spirit {or being} superior to me which produces in me the idea of extension though extension does not actually exist? Yet, when I consider the thing attentively I find that my conclusion is good, and that no spirit {or being} how excellent soever can cause the idea which I have of extension to represent to me extension rather than anything else if extension does not actually exist, because if he should do so, the idea which I should then have of extension would not be a representation of extension but a representation of nothing, which is impossible."

"But it may be I still deceive myself when I say that the idea I have of extension supposes an object actually existing. For it seems that I have ideas which do not suppose any object. I have, for example, the idea of an enchanted castle, though no such thing really exists. Yet, when I consider the difficulty more attentively, I find there is this difference between the idea of extension and that of an enchanted castle, that the first, being natural, that is, independent of my will, supposes an object which is necessarily such as it represents, whereas the other, being artificial, supposes indeed an object, but it is not necessary that that object be absolutely such as the idea represents because my will can add to that object or diminish from it as it pleases, as I have before said and as I shall prove hereafter, when I come to treat of the origin of ideas." P. S. Regis, *Cours Entier de Philosophie ou Systeme General selon les Principes de M. Descartes* (Amsterdam, 1691; reprint New York, Johnson Reprint Corporation, 1970), Metaphysics, Book I, Part 1, ch. 3 [vol. 1, p. 75].

the contrary, yet he may possibly neglect to conceive this; though no man can possibly think that twice two is not four, yet he may possibly be stupid and never have thought at all whether it be so or not). But this I say: there is no man who thinks or reasons at all but may easily become more certain that there is something eternal, infinite, and self-existing than he can be certain of anything else.

Thirdly, hence we may observe that our first certainty of the existence of God does not arise from this, that in the idea our minds frame of him (or rather in the definition that we make of the word *God* as signifying a being of all possible perfections) we include self-existence, but from hence, that it is demonstrable both negatively, that neither can all things possibly have arisen out of nothing, nor can they have depended one on another in an endless succession, and also positively, that there is something in the universe actually existing without us, the supposition of whose not existing plainly implies a contradiction. The argument which has by some been drawn from our including self-existence in the *idea* of God, or our comprehending it in the *definition* or *notion* we frame of him, has this obscurity and defect in it: that it seems to extend only to the nominal idea or mere definition of a self-existent being, and does not with a sufficiently evident connection refer and apply that general nominal idea, definition, or notion which we frame in our own mind, to any real particular being actually existing without us. For it is not satisfactory that I have in my mind an idea of the proposition "there exists a being endowed with all possible perfections" or "there is a self-existent being." But I must also have some idea of the thing. I must have an idea of something actually existing without me. And I must see wherein consists the absolute impossibility of removing that idea, and consequently of supposing the non-existence of the thing before I can be satisfied from that idea that the thing actually exists. The bare having an idea of the proposition "there is a self-existent being" proves indeed the thing not to be impossible, for of an impossible proposition there can be no idea. But that it actually is, cannot be proved from the idea unless the certainty of the actual existence of a necessarily existing being follows from the possibility of the existence of such a being, which that it does in this particular case many learned men have indeed thought, and their subtle arguings upon this head are sufficient to raise a cloud not very easy to be seen through.

But it is a much clearer and more convincing way of arguing, to demonstrate that there does actually exist without us a being whose existence is

necessary and of itself, by showing the evident contradiction contained in the contrary supposition (as I have before done), and at the same time the absolute impossibility of destroying or removing some ideas, as of eternity and immensity, which therefore must needs be modes or attributes of a necessary being actually existing. For if I have in my mind an idea of a thing, and cannot possibly in my imagination take away the idea of that thing as actually existing any more than I can change or take away the idea of the equality of twice two to four, the certainty of the existence of that thing is the same, and stands on the same foundation, as the certainty of the other relation. For the relation of equality between twice two and four has no other certainty but this, that I cannot, without a contradiction, change or take away the idea of that relation. We are certain, therefore, of the being of a supreme independent cause because it is strictly demonstrable that there is some thing in the universe actually existing without us, the supposition of whose not-existing plainly implies a contradiction.

Some writers have contended that it is preposterous to inquire in this manner at all into the ground or reason of the existence of the first cause, because evidently the first cause can have nothing prior to it, and consequently must needs (they think) exist absolutely without any cause at all.⁸ That the first cause can have no other *being* prior to it, to be the cause of its existence, is indeed self-evident. But if originally, absolutely, and antecedently to all supposition of existence, there be no necessary ground or reason why the first cause does exist rather than not exist, if the first cause can rightly and truly be affirmed to exist absolutely without any ground or reason of existence at all, it will unavoidably follow, by the same argument, that it may as well cease likewise to exist without any ground or reason of ceasing to exist, which is absurd. The truth, therefore, plainly is: whatever is the true reason why the first cause can never possibly cease to exist, the same is and originally and always was the true reason why it always did and cannot but exist, that is, it is the true ground and reason of its existence.

Fourthly, from hence it follows that the material world cannot possibly be the first and original being, uncreated, independent, and of itself eternal. For, since it has been already demonstrated that whatever being has existed from eternity, independent, and without an external cause of

⁸ See the answer to a Seventh Letter at the end of this book [Supplementary text III].

its existence, must be self-existent, and that whatever is self-existent must exist necessarily by an absolute necessity in the nature of the thing itself, it follows evidently that unless the material world exists necessarily by an absolute necessity in its own nature, so as that it must be an express contradiction to suppose it not to exist, it cannot be independent and of itself eternal. Now that the material world does not exist thus necessarily is very evident. For absolute necessity of existing and a possibility of not existing being contradictory ideas, it is manifest the material world cannot exist necessarily, if without a contradiction we can conceive it either not to be or to be in any respect otherwise than it now is. Than which nothing is more easy. For whether we consider the form of the world with the disposition and motion of its parts, or whether we consider the matter of it as such, without respect to its present form, every thing in it, both the whole and every one of its parts, their situation and motion, the form and also the matter, are the most arbitrary and dependent things and the farthest removed from necessity that can possibly be imagined. A necessity indeed of fitness, that is, a necessity that things should be as they are in order to the well-being of the whole, there may be in all these things; but an absolute necessity of nature in any of them (which is what the atheist must maintain), there is not the least appearance of. If any man will say in this sense (as every atheist must do) either that the form of the world, or at least the matter and motion of it, is necessary, nothing can possibly be invented more absurd.

If he says that the particular form is necessary, that is, that the world and all things that are therein exist by necessity of nature, he must affirm it to be a contradiction to suppose that any part of the world can be in any respect otherwise than it now is. It must be a contradiction in terms to suppose more or fewer stars, more or fewer planets, or to suppose their size, figure, or motion different from what it now is, or to suppose more or fewer plants and animals upon Earth or the present ones of different shape and bigness from what they now are. In all which things there is the greatest arbitrariness in respect of power and possibility that can be imagined, however necessary any of them may be in respect of wisdom and preservation of the beauty and order of the whole.

If the atheist will say that the motion in general of all matter is necessary, it follows that it must be a contradiction in terms to suppose any matter to be at rest, which is so absurd and ridiculous that I think hardly any atheists, either ancient or modern, have presumed directly to suppose it.

[...]